rise of cities like Kolkata and Mumbai in India and Yangon and Dubai abroad. It produced a number of freedom fighters and political leaders who went on to become Presidents and Bharat Ratna awardees. It popularized various types of regional cultures, cinemas and culinary delights. In short, it played a significant role in shaping the history of modern India. Surprisingly, it is a story that has never been told.

In order to understand the Great Indian Migration Wave and see how it is different from other migration streams within India, it is important to define its features. It is mass migration that is male-dominated, semi-permanent and remittance-yielding. Mass migration is considered to arise from a *source* region where usually over 20 per cent of the households report outmigration or over 5 per cent of the population is enumerated outside.[1] By 'male-dominated', I mean that over 70 per cent of the net outflow of migrants from a particular region comprises men. Semi-permanent durations are those where migrants spend a greater part of the year away from their homes and who do not permanently settle in their destinations. They return after working outside for a few years or even decades. Remittances are the inevitable outcome of such migrations to support families back home. Of course, some individuals and families do settle away from home, but the bulk of the migrations do not lead to permanent settlement.

The wave I refer to represents peaks and troughs in this migration episode which occurred at different points in different regions. Broadly, this wave mirrors India's engagement with the global economy, rising from the late 19th century to the 1930s and then once again since economic liberalization was introduced in 1991. These migrations have fundamentally been labour migrations towards plantations, mines and cities, but they can include a variety of other skills and occupations. Geographically, the maximum source-region impact of the wave is observed in the coastal belts, lower Indo-Gangetic plains and the northern Himalayan range. A remarkable aspect of the Great Indian Migration Wave is the near constancy of the source areas but, literally, a sea change in the destinations from the Bay of Bengal towards the Arabian Sea. How and why did these migrations